SCHOOLS OF VEDĀNTA — IDENTITY, QUALIFICATION AND DIFFERENCE

ONE CANON, SIX SCHOOLS → ULTIMATE REALITY AND ITS CAUSALITY → HOW IT IS KNOWN → LORD, SELF, INDIVIDUAL, WORLD → ILLUSION, IGNORANCE, SUPERIMPOSITION, ERROR → THE GREAT SENTENCE → LIBERATION → INSEPARABLE DEPENDENCE AND FIVEFOLD DIFFERENCE → WIDER SCHOOLS AND THE GRADED VERDICT

- ● PRIMARY CORE FLOW
- ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA
- ● APPROVAL PENDING

Read the cyan rail from Stage 00 to the closing verdict. Each stage uses a structure chosen for its own content: chain, matrix, ladder, table, panel and comparison. The single grey stage at the foot is optional enrichment only.

00 STAGE 00 ONE CANON, SIX COMMENTARIAL SCHOOLS — THE INTERPRETIVE PROBLEM

- ● PRASTHĀNA-TRAYĪ — THREEFOLD CANON
- ● ŚRUTI · SMṚTI · NYĀYA PRASTHĀNA
- ● SIX COMMENTARIAL SETTLEMENTS
- ● IDENTITY · QUALIFICATION · DIFFERENCE
- ● SYLLABUS ITEM 19 — ELEVEN PRINTED TERMS
- ● 20 PRIMARY-OWNED PYQ PARTS, 2018–2025

PRINCIPAL UPANIṢADS — revealed foundation (śruti-prasthāna) → BHAGAVAD GĪTĀ — remembered synthesis coordinating knowledge, devotion, action → BRAHMA SŪTRA of Bādarāyaṇa — reasoned systematization; COMPACT aphorisms → THEREFORE competing commentaries: the canon is shared, the reading is not

IDENTITY — ADVAITA (Śaṅkara)
- Brahma-sūtra-bhāṣya and Upaniṣad/Gītā commentaries
- difference is ignorance-conditioned appearance
- PRICE: world, individuality, ethics and devotion become lower-order

QUALIFICATION — VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA (Rāmānuja)
- Śrī-bhāṣya, Vedārthasaṅgraha, Gītā commentary
- real selves and world inseparably qualify one whole
- PRICE: real modes press on divine simplicity and changelessness

DIFFERENCE — DVAITA (Madhva)
- Brahma-sūtra-bhāṣya, Anuvyākhyāna, Gītā commentary
- God, selves and matter really differ; only God is independent
- PRICE: non-dual Upaniṣadic sentences are harder to read; hierarchy

WIDER SETTLEMENTS REQUIRED BY THE PAPERS
- Nimbārka — dualistic non-dualism: difference AND non-difference both real
- Vallabha — pure non-dualism: world is a REAL UNCHANGED manifestation
- Caitanya tradition — inconceivable difference–non-difference by divine powers

OWNERSHIP FIREWALL
- HELD HERE: Brahman-centred reading; accomplished reality (siddha-vastu)
- OWNED BY EARLIER MĪMĀṂSĀ: injunction, duty, authorless verbal authority
- the boundary is examinable: can Vedic sentences reveal a non-actional reality?

MECHANISM / VERDICT — One unamendable canon plus under-determining aphorisms forces every commentator to supply the metaphysics that saves the sentences he cannot delete.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vedanta's schools do not disagree about which texts are authoritative; they disagree about what an unamendable canon can be made to mean.

TRAP — Never write that the schools 'differ about scripture'. They agree about scripture and differ about its interpretation; only the second claim earns marks.

01 STAGE 01 ULTIMATE REALITY (BRAHMAN) — TWO DEFINITIONS AND THE ATTRIBUTES FORK

- ● SVARŪPA-LAKṢAṆA — ESSENTIAL
- ● TAṬASTHA-LAKṢAṆA — RELATIONAL
- ● SAT-CIT-ĀNANDA
- ● JANMĀDYASYA YATAḤ
- ● NIRGUṆA ≠ BLANKNESS
- ● ANANTA-KALYĀṆA-GUṆA-VIŚIṢṬA
- ● SVATANTRA / PARATANTRA

ESSENTIAL DEFINITION — WHAT IT IS
- being–consciousness–bliss (sat-cit-ānanda)
- not three accidental predicates but one essence
- use it to DEFINE the absolute in itself

RELATIONAL DEFINITION — WHY IT GROUNDS THE WORLD
- janmādyasya yatah — that from which origin, sustenance, dissolution proceed
- identifies by relation, not by nature
- use it to EXPLAIN the cosmological role

A ADVAITA — QUALITYLESS (nirguṇa) — Sole ultimately real (pāramārthika). Qualityless means free of LIMITING, relational, empirical and objectifiable attributes; it does NOT mean blankness. Creatorhood, omniscience, lordship and moral governance belong to the LORD (Īśvara) at the empirical level.

B VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA — QUALIFIED ONLY — Qualified in the highest sense: endowed with infinite auspicious qualities (ananta-kalyāṇa-guṇa-viśiṣṭa). Qualities are perfections, not limiting adjuncts. There is NO qualityless level above the personal Lord; qualification is what makes absoluteness intelligible.

C DVAITA — QUALIFIED AND INDEPENDENT — Personal Viṣṇu with perfect infinite attributes. Decisively: brahman alone is INDEPENDENT (svatantra); selves and world are DEPENDENT (paratantra). Difference is not absorbed into qualified unity but is itself ultimate.

RĀMĀNUJA'S CRITIQUE — asked 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks
- an entity without attributes cannot be known at all
- if utterly indeterminate it cannot be scripture's referent
- without internal intelligibility it cannot cause a qualified world
- passages negating DEFECTS do not negate ALL qualities

ADVAITA'S REPLY — keep it in the same paragraph
- it is not known as an OBJECT with predicates
- it is SELF-REVEALED as the ground of all knowing
- denying limiting predicates is not denying nature
- residue: the reply leans on self-luminosity, not description

MECHANISM / VERDICT — One question — attributes or no attributes — fixes the answer to every other printed term: world, Lord, self, liberation and even the status of scripture.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The dispute is not whether the absolute is one, but whether unity survives description: Sankara refuses predication, Ramanuja perfects it, Madhva replaces it with dependence.

TRAP — 'Brahman has no nature at all' and 'Ramanuja accepts both nirguna and saguna Brahman' are the two sentences that destroy this answer.

02 STAGE 02 ULTIMATE REALITY AS EFFICIENT AND MATERIAL CAUSE — 2025 Q6(b), 15 MARKS

- ● NIMITTA-KĀRAṆA — EFFICIENT
- ● UPĀDĀNA-KĀRAṆA — MATERIAL
- ● SPIDER AND WEB
- ● ROPE AND SNAKE
- ● MILK AND CURD — CONTRAST CASE
- ● SUBTLE CAUSE-STATE / GROSS EFFECT-STATE

PREMISE — nothing exists independently of ultimate reality → THEREFORE — there can be NO SECOND MATERIAL out of which the world is made → SO — it is both the intelligence behind the world and the material BASIS of its appearance → BUT — apparent transformation (vivarta) makes 'material cause' mean SUBSTRATE, not transformed stuff

SCHOOL	EFFICIENT CAUSE	MATERIAL CAUSE	CONTROLLING QUALIFICATION
ADVAITA	the absolute	the absolute, as substrate only	vivarta: no real modification; spider spins the web out of itself, rope never becomes the snake
VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA	the absolute	the absolute, through its modes	REAL causation: subtle conscious and non-conscious modes become gross; God's essence uncorrupted
DVAITA	God (Viṣṇu) alone	dependent primordial matter (prakṛti)	God is NOT the material cause; dependence is universal, difference remains real and eternal
SĀṂKHYA	none — no creator God	unconscious prakṛti	splits material causality from intelligence
NYĀYA	God	eternal atoms	splits efficient from material causality

READ THE EXAMPLES AS ARGUMENTS
- SPIDER: one source supplies both agency and material
- ROPE: a substrate supports an appearance it never becomes
- MILK/CURD: the real-transformation case that Advaita rejects

THE COMPARATIVE LINE THAT SCORES
- Sāṃkhya splits material causality from intelligence
- Nyāya splits efficient from material causality
- Vedānta reunites both — except in Dvaita

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The double causality is a NEGATIVE thesis first: there is no second material principle, and the world's being is borrowed from its substrate rather than produced by modifying it.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita calls the absolute the material cause only to deny that there is any other material; apparent transformation then ensures that being the world's stuff never means becoming it.

TRAP — 'All Vedanta schools hold Brahman to be both efficient and material cause' is false: Madhva denies material causality of God explicitly.

03 STAGE 03 SIX MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE — AND WHY TESTIMONY ALONE REACHES THE ABSOLUTE

- ● PRAMĀTṚ – PRAMĀṆA – PRAMEYA
- ● SIX FOR ADVAITA, THREE FOR THE OTHERS
- ● ŚĀSTRA-YONI / ŚĀSTRA-PRAMĀṆAKA
- ● KATAKA — THE CLEARING-NUT
- ● SARVAṂ VIJÑĀNAṂ SAVIŚEṢAM
- ● SĀKṢIN AS INTERNAL VALIDATOR

INSTRUMENT	ONE-LINE DEFINITION	STANDARD EXAMPLE
PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa)	immediate cognition through sense-contact with a present object	'this pot is blue'
INFERENCE (anumāna)	unperceived fact through a perceived mark (liṅga) and concomitance (vyāpti)	smoke on the hill, therefore fire
COMPARISON (upamāna)	fresh cognition of an absent familiar object's similarity to what is seen	the gavaya seen; the remembered cow is like it
TESTIMONY (śabda)	valid cognition from reliable words, supremely the authorless (apauruṣeya) Veda	the great sentence teaches self–absolute identity
POSTULATION (arthāpatti)	presumption of an unseen fact required to reconcile incompatible known facts	fat Devadatta does not eat by day, so he eats at night
NON-APPREHENSION (anupalabdhi)	cognition of absence through non-perception under proper conditions	'there is no pot on the floor'

EVERY instrument presupposes knower – means – known → THAT TRIAD presupposes DUALITY, so all six work only at the EMPIRICAL level → PUZZLE: how then does testimony establish the ULTIMATE truth? → REPLY: it removes ignorance and lapses WITH it — the clearing-nut settles with the mud

WHY NOT THE OTHER FIVE
- perception: the absolute is qualityless and non-objectifiable
- inference: no perceived instance, no uniquely co-present mark
- an inferred absolute would become an inferred OBJECT (prameya)
- comparison, postulation, non-apprehension are empirically parasitic

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA — THREE
- perception, inference, testimony; the rest reduced to these
- ACCEPTS indeterminate perception but REDEFINES it
- rejects cognition of a wholly qualifierless (nirviśeṣa) object

DVAITA — THREE
- perception, inference, scriptural tradition (āgama)
- kevala-pramāṇa / anu-pramāṇa distinction; expositions vary
- the WITNESS (sākṣin) validates REAL DIFFERENCE, not non-duality

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A school's instrument-count tracks its metaphysics: Advaita needs testimony for a non-objective absolute, Ramanuja needs all cognition qualified, Madhva needs instruments that secure difference.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita's epistemology is deliberately generous and deliberately self-limiting: six instruments account for ordinary life, and the one that reaches the absolute dissolves with the ignorance it removes.

TRAP — 'Advaita rejects perception and inference' converts a two-level epistemology into scepticism; and 'Ramanuja denies nirvikalpaka perception' misstates a redefinition as a rejection.

04 STAGE 04 THE LORD (ĪŚVARA) AND THE ORIGINAL–REFLECTION MODEL — 2025 Q8(a), 20 MARKS

- ● MĀYĀ-UPAHITA BRAHMAN
- ● BIMBA — ORIGINAL
- ● PRATIBIMBA — REFLECTION
- ● AVACCHEDA · PRATIBIMBA · ĀBHĀSA
- ● GHAṬĀKĀŚA — POT-SPACE
- ● SOTERIOLOGICAL HALF OF THE QUESTION

ADVAITA
- the Lord = the absolute conditioned by illusion (māyā-upahita brahman)
- omniscient, omnipotent, moral governor, creator of the empirical world
- FULLY REAL at the empirical level; sublated at the ultimate level

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA
- the Lord IS the absolute — supreme personal Viṣṇu-Nārāyaṇa
- no qualityless level above him; qualities real and eternal
- immanent as indweller of his body, transcendent as exceeding it

DVAITA
- Viṣṇu absolutely supreme, alone independent and self-sufficient
- all selves and world depend ontologically, morally, soteriologically
- difference is never erased, not even by liberation

ORIGINAL (bimba) = pure consciousness → reflected in a CONDITIONING MEDIUM — the internal organ under ignorance → REFLECTION (pratibimba) = the empirical self; the original is UNAFFECTED → SOTERIOLOGY: the reflection has only DERIVATIVE reality, so liberation is RECOGNITION, not movement or merging

VARIANTS — NAME THE MODEL YOU USE
- cosmic reflection read as the Lord; individual reflections as selves
- other accounts make the Lord original relative to the individual
- later explanatory alternatives, not one uniform proposition of Śaṅkara

RIVAL MODELS INSIDE ADVAITA
- limitation (avaccheda-vāda): one space as many pot-spaces
- semblance (ābhāsa-vāda): individuality is ontologically thin
- all three converge: individuality lacks ultimate reality

LIMITS OF THE METAPHOR
- formless original and formless medium cannot literally reflect
- reflection normally needs a spatial gap, which non-duality forbids
- Madhva uses the SAME image to argue REAL DIFFERENCE

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The 2022 hierarchy follows: witness closest to the ultimate standpoint, individual in empirical bondage, Lord in cosmic-ordering empirical reality — one consciousness under three descriptions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The original-reflection model is not a picture of how consciousness divides but an argument that it never did: what is reflected borrows all its being from the original.

TRAP — 'Advaita denies God' is false: the Lord is fully real at the empirical level, and only ultimacy is withheld. Do not answer 2025 with ontology alone.

05 STAGE 05 THE TRUE SELF (ĀTMAN) AND THE WITNESS (SĀKṢĪ) — 2020 Q8(c), 15 MARKS

- ● JĀGRAT · SVAPNA · SUṢUPTI
- ● TURĪYA — NOT A FOURTH EPISODE
- ● SVAYAṂ-PRAKĀŚA
- ● AṆU — ATOMIC KNOWER
- ● DHARMA-BHŪTA-JÑĀNA
- ● CHANGING PSYCHOLOGY vs CHANGELESS CONSCIOUSNESS

WAKING — an external object-world is presented → DREAM — internally generated objects are presented → DEEP SLEEP — no manifest subject-object cognition → 'I slept peacefully; I knew nothing' presupposes CONTINUITY, supporting a WITNESS

WHAT THE WITNESS IS
- illumines all mental states and is altered by none
- pleasure, pain, doubt, memory, desire are witnessed, not essential
- not a passive blank but the CONDITION for all experience
- self-luminous: manifestation belongs to consciousness as its nature

WHAT IT IS NOT
- not a second knower sitting inside the person
- not a fourth state in a temporal series
- the fourth standpoint UNDERLIES and illumines all three states

THE HONEST QUALIFICATION
- the argument is internal to Advaita, not a neutral proof
- Rāmānuja and Nyāya keep an enduring self and reject the identity
- it establishes an enduring witness more securely than non-duality

A ADVAITA — pure consciousness — Identical in essence with the absolute; the great sentences express that identity; the empirical self appears individual only through ignorance.

B VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA — real atomic knower — Real, eternal, atomic (aṇu), self-luminous. Its ATTRIBUTIVE CONSCIOUSNESS (dharma-bhūta-jñāna) reveals objects, contracts under karmic obstruction and expands in liberation — so atomic size never confines cognitive range.

C DVAITA — real dependent self — Real, eternal, dependent upon God. Difference from God is fundamental, not ignorance-produced; the self never becomes God, and devotion is a permanent relation rather than a provisional means.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Self IS the absolute -> liberation is RECOGNITION. Self is a MODE -> liberation is COMMUNION. Self is permanently DIFFERENT -> liberation is SERVICE.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Every school agrees that something in us endures; they divide on whether that witness is the absolute, a real mode of it, or a real dependent that must never be mistaken for it.

TRAP — Do not present the deep-sleep argument as a knock-down proof of non-duality, and do not describe the witness as a soul watching the mind.

06 STAGE 06 THE INDIVIDUAL SELF (JĪVA) — THREE NON-DUAL MODELS, TWO REALIST RIVALS

- ● ĀTMAN vs JĪVA — MARK IT FIRST
- ● AVACCHEDA-VĀDA — VĀCASPATI MIŚRA
- ● PRATIBIMBA-VĀDA — PADMAPĀDA, VIVARAṆA
- ● ĀBHĀSA-VĀDA
- ● PRAKĀRA — REAL MODE
- ● NITYA · MUKTA · BADDHA

LIMITATION (avaccheda-vāda)
- the absolute appears as individual when DELIMITED by ignorance
- one space seems many through pots (ghaṭākāśa)
- no real fragment; apparent limitation alone produces plurality

REFLECTION (pratibimba-vāda)
- the individual is the REFLECTION of consciousness in ignorance
- one face in a mirror: the image appears individual, original unaffected
- explains dependence AND phenomenological vividness

SEMBLANCE (ābhāsa-vāda)
- the individual is a MERE SEMBLANCE of the absolute
- pushes derivative status further than reflection theory
- common conclusion: individuality lacks ultimate reality

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA — REAL CONSCIOUS MODE
- a real conscious mode (prakāra), neither illusion nor detached substance
- body-soul analogy: depends entirely for existence, support and activity
- 'body' is FUNCTIONAL — what is controlled, sustained and used

DVAITA — REAL DEPENDENT SUBSTANCE
- never reducible to God, never a mode, never illusory
- difference AMONG selves is also real
- eternally free (nitya) · liberated (mukta) · bound (baddha)
- bound souls further classified; hierarchy is contested — evaluate it

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Three Advaita models answer three different pressures — how one can be many, why the many feels real, and how the many is kept weightless — and converge on one conclusion.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita explains the individual three times over because individuality resists a single explanation, and all three explanations end in the same verdict.

TRAP — Do not swap the associations: limitation is Vacaspati Misra with pot-space, reflection is Padmapada and the Vivarana line with the mirrored face.

07 STAGE 07 THE WORLD (JAGAT) — THREE LEVELS OF REALITY AND THREE VERDICTS

- ● PĀRAMĀRTHIKA · VYĀVAHĀRIKA · PRĀTIBHĀSIKA
- ● MITHYĀ ≠ TUCCHA
- ● BĀDHA — SUBLATION GRADES REALITY
- ● TRIKĀLĀBĀDHITA
- ● ACIT — THE DIVINE BODY
- ● STRONGEST REALISM: DVAITA

1 ULTIMATE (pāramārthika) — The absolute alone; never sublated (trikālābādhita). This is the only grade that is unconditionally real.

2 EMPIRICAL (vyāvahārika) — The world, the Lord and individual selves: valid, coherent, PUBLIC, law-governed and intersubjective. Sublated only by knowledge of the absolute — which is why denying ultimacy is not denying validity.

3 APPARENT (prātibhāsika) — Dream, rope-snake, shell-silver: private, cancelled inside empirical experience itself. Placing the world here is the commonest error in the whole clause.

ISSUE	ŚAṂKARA	RĀMĀNUJA	MADHVA
reality of the world	mithyā: dependent, sublatable appearance — NOT wholly non-existent	real manifestation; the non-conscious (acit) dimension of the absolute's body	real and eternally distinct; dependence does not cancel distinctness
change in the absolute	denied outright	accepted in a qualified sense, through modes	no material causality at all, so the question does not arise
soteriology	the world is sublated in knowledge	the world is meaningful in devotion	the world is the permanent field of service
God–world relation	empirical	intrinsic body–soul relation	efficient governance of a really distinct order

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Sankara protects ABSOLUTENESS by reducing world-status; Ramanuja protects WORLD-STATUS by qualifying absoluteness; Madhva protects both by making dependence, not identity, the bond. Shared ground first: total dependence, no second principle, scripture final.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita does not say the world is unreal; it says the world is not independently real — and a world that can be cancelled but cannot be dismissed is exactly what a non-dual absolute requires.

TRAP — Equating mithya with tuccha converts a graded ontology into nihilism and forfeits the 2021 and 2022 world-status questions.

08 STAGE 08 APPARENT VERSUS REAL TRANSFORMATION — 2022 Q5(e), 10 MARKS

- ● PARIṆĀMA-VĀDA — MILK TO CURD
- ● VIVARTA — ROPE TO SNAKE
- ● STRUCTURAL AGREEMENT
- ● ONTOLOGICAL RUPTURE
- ● GRADED VERDICT REQUIRED

THE CASE FOR 'DEVELOPMENT'
- both refuse production from nothing
- both make the effect cause-dependent
- if the cause is the absolute, and it admits no modification, the effect cannot be real AS transformation
- so transformation must be only apparent

THE CASE AGAINST
- the two give CONTRARY ontological status to the effect
- what real transformation most insists on — genuine change in the cause — is abandoned
- a doctrine denying another's core commitment is a REJECTION, not a completion

POSITION	SCHOOL	WHAT HAPPENS TO THE CAUSE	WHAT HAPPENS TO THE EFFECT
apparent transformation	Advaita	wholly unchanged substrate	sublatable appearance dependent on the substrate
real transformation	Sāṃkhya	really modified	a real altered state of the same stuff
real transformation of modes	Rāmānuja	essence uncorrupted; modes transform	real, from subtle cause-state to gross effect-state
real transformation of powers	Nimbārka	dependent powers transform	real and dependent, neither illusion nor second absolute
unchanged real manifestation	Vallabha	unaltered	REAL, and never sublated

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Agreement is STRUCTURAL, disagreement is ONTOLOGICAL: apparent transformation develops the search for a dependent effect and abandons the commitment to real change.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vivarta inherits the architecture of parinama and reverses its content, which is why the honest answer is neither yes nor no but graded.

TRAP — The stem's word is 'development'. A flat yes or a flat no forfeits the question regardless of how accurate the exposition is.

09 STAGE 09 ILLUSION (MĀYĀ) AND IGNORANCE (AVIDYĀ) — TWO INDESCRIBABILITIES, ONE UNSOLVED LOCUS

- ● ANIRVACANĪYA
- ● ĀVARAṆA — CONCEALMENT
- ● VIKṢEPA — PROJECTION
- ● ANĀDI YET SĀNTA
- ● BHĀVA-RŪPA — POSITIVE IN FORM
- ● ĀŚRAYA / VIṢAYA PROBLEM

INDESCRIBABILITY OF THE ABSOLUTE — A SURPLUS
- non-dual and non-objectifiable, so it exceeds limiting predication
- it does NOT mean uncertain reality
- the UNSUBLATED reality because of which description is possible

INDESCRIBABILITY OF ILLUSION — AN INDETERMINACY
- not ultimately real, because it is sublated
- not sheer non-being, because it is experienced
- a dependent, sublatable explanatory principle

TWO POWERS: concealment hides the absolute's nature → projection throws up the world of names and forms → together they explain how ignorance both COVERS and FABRICATES → the same pair returns as the two components of superimposition

? ILLUSION OR IGNORANCE — GENUINELY NON-UNIFORM — Some formulations treat them as interchangeable. Others make illusion cosmic and objective, associated with the Lord, and ignorance individual and subjective, associated with the self. Both are usually called indescribable. State the distinction AND record the variation.

! THE LOCUS-AND-OBJECT PROBLEM — If ignorance belongs to the individual the account is circular, since the individual arises within ignorance. If it belongs to the absolute, the absolute appears compromised. This is the doorway to the seven objections.

= THE REALIST ALTERNATIVES — Ramanuja: no indescribable cosmic principle — ignorance is REAL ignorance of God and of the soul's dependence, removed by knowledge with devotion and surrender. Madhva: ignorance is real, not a veil over identity, overcome by knowledge, devotion and grace.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Ignorance is beginningless (anadi) yet terminable (santa) and positive in form (bhava-rupa) — a bare absence could not both conceal and project.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita uses one word for two opposite reasons: the absolute escapes description because it is too real to be an object, illusion because it is not real enough to be either being or non-being.

TRAP — Flattening illusion and ignorance into synonyms, or asserting the distinction as universal, both lose marks. State it, then qualify it.

10 STAGE 10 THE SEVEN OBJECTIONS (SAPTA-ANUPAPATTI) — 2025 Q5(d), 10 MARKS

- ● NAMES AND ORDER VARY
- ● VIVARAṆA vs BHĀMATĪ
- ● SĀKṢI-PRATYAKṢA
- ● AKHAṆḌĀKĀRA-VṚTTI
- ● STRONGEST: LOCUS AND MEANS OF KNOWING
- ● WEAKEST: CONCEALMENT AND CESSATION

OBJECTION	THE CHARGE	ADVAITA'S REPLY	RESIDUE
1 LOCUS (āśraya)	in the absolute it defiles; in the individual it presupposes what it explains — mutual dependence	Vivaraṇa: the absolute is locus without modification. Bhāmatī: the individual, with a beginningless relation	hardest: two sub-schools give two answers
2 CONCEALMENT (tirodhāna)	a self-luminous reality cannot be concealed without destroying its nature	it conceals the absolute only as recognised by the individual; a cloud obstructs the viewer, not the sun	how can obstruction arise at all if the absolute alone is real?
3 NATURE (svarūpa)	something neither real nor unreal has no coherent nature	the trichotomy: experienced, so not non-being; sublated, so not being	works only if sublatability grades reality
4 INDEFINABILITY	a third category names the problem rather than solving it	grades of sublatability, not bare contradictories; and the non-conscious mode is itself a third status	called verbal unless the grade is independently grounded
5 MEANS OF KNOWING	no instrument establishes a positive ignorance	witness-perception of 'I do not know', postulation from the fact that knowledge removes bondage, and scripture	'I do not know' can be read as absence: most dangerous with (1)
6 REMOVER (nivartaka)	contentless knowledge cannot remove it; determinate knowledge lies within it	the undivided-form mental mode sublates the false and then subsides, like the stick consumed in the pyre	how can a mode within the empirical order end that order?
7 CESSATION (nivṛtti)	if real it cannot be removed; if unreal there is nothing to remove	cessation is no fifth entity: the absolute simply remains as it always was	elegant if superimposition is granted; otherwise question-begging

RĀMĀNUJA'S POSITIVE ALTERNATIVE
- inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi): real modes, really distinct
- body-soul relation: the absolute indwells and controls its body
- apprehension of the real (satkhyāti) with elemental intermixture

DVAITA'S THIRD ROUTE
- no illusion in the Advaita sense; the world and ignorance are both real
- error as apprehension otherwise, newly analysed
- difference is made fundamental rather than absorbed into unity

THE 2018 PRINTED ANOMALY — Q7(c)
- the paper asks why illusion is 'needed by both'
- FLAG it; Rāmānuja rejects Advaitic illusion
- read it as comparing how each system explains PLURALITY

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The seven attack three levels at once: the STATUS of ignorance, the POSSIBILITY of concealment and projection, and the COHERENCE of liberation as its removal.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The seven objections are one bill presented seven times: Advaita introduced an indescribable power to save non-duality, and every question about it asks Advaita to pay for the saving.

TRAP — 'Examine' is not 'enumerate': a list of seven charges without replies and without a verdict on their relative force cannot score.

11 STAGE 11 SUPERIMPOSITION (ADHYĀSA) AND THE FOUR THEORIES OF ERROR — 2021 Q7(a), 20 MARKS

- ● ATASMIN TAD-BUDDHIḤ
- ● NAISARGIKA AND ANĀDI
- ● ĀVARAṆA + VIKṢEPA
- ● PROCESS vs STATUS
- ● BĀDHA AS CRITERION
- ● ŚRĪHARṢA — DIALECTICAL, NOT CONSTRUCTIVE

'I am tall' · 'I am happy' · 'I act' · 'I know' → attributes of the OBJECT are put on the SUBJECT, and the subject's on the object → natural (naisargika) and beginningless (anādi) — prior to reflection → therefore ordinary experience is STRUCTURALLY pervaded, not occasionally mistaken

THEORY	SCHOOL	WHAT THE PRESENTED SILVER IS	ADVAITA'S VERDICT
apprehension otherwise (anyathā-khyāti)	Nyāya	real silver known elsewhere, wrongly connected with this locus	correction cancels it AT THE LOCUS rather than relocating it; and it is practically effective
apprehension of the real (satkhyāti)	Viśiṣṭādvaita	a real silver-element in the shell, by elemental intermixture	keeps realism at the cost of an elaborate physical mechanism
apprehension of the non-existent (asat-khyāti)	Buddhist	sheer non-being	rejected: the illusory silver APPEARS, and non-being cannot appear
indescribable error (anirvacanīya-khyāti)	Advaita	neither being nor non-being: experienced yet sublated	the epistemological miniature of the metaphysics

THE PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER
- being = never sublated; non-being = never presented; indescribable = presented then sublated
- sublation (bādha) is the criterion of degrees of reality
- experience gives the object SOME positive status
- ignorance is positive in form, else it could not conceal AND project

THE HONEST LIMITS
- the refutation shows an ANOMALY for Nyāya, not a proof of the third grade
- the positive argument works only if sublatability is accepted
- Rāmānuja and Madhva call the third grade verbal
- Śrīharṣa refutes definitions of the real rather than supplying one

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Superimposition is the PROCESS; indescribable-error theory states the STATUS of its product. Connect them; conflating them makes the argument circular.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: What shell-silver is to shell, the world is to the absolute — and superimposition names the process by which the mistake is made about oneself rather than about a shell.

TRAP — Never write that the illusory silver 'does not exist': the whole point is that non-existence cannot appear.

12 STAGE 12 THE GREAT SENTENCE 'THAT THOU ART' — 2023 Q5(c), 10 MARKS

- ● VĀCYĀRTHA — DIRECT MEANING
- ● LAKṢYĀRTHA — IMPLIED MEANING
- ● BHĀGA-TYĀGA-LAKṢAṆĀ
- ● JAHAD-AJAHAL-LAKṢAṆĀ
- ● SO'YAṂ DEVADATTAḤ
- ● SUMMARY VERSE ≠ MAHĀVĀKYA

TAT — 'THAT'
- direct meaning: the Lord associated with illusion
- omniscient · remote · cosmic cause · lordship
- implied meaning: PURE CONSCIOUSNESS

TVAM — 'THOU'
- direct meaning: the individual associated with ignorance
- finite · immediate · agent · ignorant
- implied meaning: PURE CONSCIOUSNESS

the DIRECT meanings conflict → ABANDON the incompatible portions of both → RETAIN the common implied meaning → IDENTITY OF ESSENCE, not sameness of empirical condition

THE CANONICAL PARALLEL
- 'this is that Devadatta': drop then-there and now-here
- keep the identical person
- implication is an ordinary semantic operation, not an ad hoc rescue
- the mixed variety is used — neither total abandonment nor total retention

RIVAL READINGS AND TEXTUAL CAUTION
- Viśiṣṭādvaita and Dvaita read dependence, participation or special relation
- for Rāmānuja 'thou' names a self whose nature is to be an inseparable mode
- 'Brahma satyam jagan-mithyā' is a TRADITIONAL SUMMARY, not one of the four great sentences
- the four are: tat tvam asi · aham brahmāsmi · prajñānam brahma · ayam ātmā brahma

MECHANISM / VERDICT — One sentence becomes the battleground for the whole architecture of Vedanta, because the semantics chosen decides whether difference is appearance, qualification or fact.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita reads the sentence by the ordinary logic of identity across two modes of presentation, dropping the incompatible descriptions so that the one thing both were about can be recognised.

TRAP — Quoting the Devadatta case as decoration rather than as the argument, and calling the summary verse a mahavakya, are the two standard losses here.

13 STAGE 13 LIBERATION (MOKṢA) — RECOGNITION, COMMUNION AND SERVICE

- ● PRĀPTASYA PRĀPTIḤ
- ● SĀDHANA-CATUṢṬAYA
- ● ŚRAVAṆA · MANANA · NIDIDHYĀSANA
- ● JĪVANMUKTI · PRĀRABDHA
- ● BHAKTI · PRAPATTI · PRASĀDA
- ● TĀRATAMYA — GRADATION

A ADVAITA — RECOGNITION — Liberation is attainment of what is already attained: the self is always the absolute, bondage is ignorance alone, so knowledge alone is the direct means. Action and worship purify but do not combine with knowledge — the rejection of the knowledge-and-action combination. Liberation while living follows: the body continues by commenced karma, like an arrow already released.

B VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA — COMMUNION — Recovery of the self's unobstructed nature and likeness to God in eternal loving communion and service, without numerical identity. Devotion matured from disinterested action, self-surrender as the inclusive route, and grace are indispensable; attributive consciousness becomes unrestricted. No liberation while living in the strict Advaita sense.

C DVAITA — SERVICE — Eternal blissful service of Viṣṇu, through right knowledge of his supremacy, devotion and grace. Difference is never abolished, and gradation means released souls do not enjoy identical rank or bliss. The severe classification of some bound souls is doctrinally supportable but philosophically contested.

ISSUE — 2022 Q8(c)	RĀMĀNUJA	MADHVA
God–self relation	inseparable mode and body of the absolute	distinct dependent substance, expressly NOT God's body
liberated individuality	retained in communion and service	retained in eternal difference and service
knowledge and bliss	obstruction removed; attributive knowledge unrestricted	degree of knowledge and bliss follows a real hierarchy
equality of the liberated	alike in essential type; no intrinsic gradation	gradation (tāratamya) is retained
causal background	efficient AND material cause through real modes	God efficient; dependent primordial matter material
cost of the position	pressure on divine simplicity	pressure on moral universality

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Liberation is each school's ontology restated soteriologically, which is why a liberation question can be answered only by first stating the ontology.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vedanta's three liberations are three diagnoses: where bondage is a false belief, release is recognition; where it is obstruction, communion; where it is misrelation to a permanently other Lord, service.

TRAP — 'Both are devotional' is the flattening the 2022 comparison penalises; and liberation while living belongs to Advaita, not to the realist theisms.

14 STAGE 14 INSEPARABLE DEPENDENCE (APṚTHAKSIDDHI) AND FIVEFOLD DIFFERENCE (PAÑCAVIDHABHEDA)

- ● APṚTHAKSIDDHA-VIŚEṢAṆA
- ● ŚARĪRA-ŚARĪRĪ-BHĀVA — 2024 Q5(e)
- ● SUPPORT · CONTROL · PURPOSE
- ● PAÑCAVIDHABHEDA — 2020 Q5(d)
- ● SVATANTRA / PARATANTRA
- ● VIŚEṢA — EXPOSITIONS VARY

INSEPARABLE DEPENDENCE — THE MIDDLE POSITION
- conscious selves and non-conscious matter are REAL and DISTINCT
- they cannot exist or be conceived apart from the absolute
- yet they are NOT identical with it
- stronger than a conceptual relation, weaker than identity; a mode is not a part

THE BODY–SOUL RELATION — THREE CONDITIONS
- entirely SUPPORTED by the indwelling self
- entirely CONTROLLED by it
- existing FOR ITS PURPOSES
- 'body' is functional, so conscious selves also qualify
- ASYMMETRY: God is untouched by the world-body's defects

1 jīva–īśvara-bheda — Soul differs from God. Consequence: devotion is NEVER transcended; it is the permanent form of the relation rather than a means to be discarded.

2 jīva–jīva-bheda — Soul differs from soul. Consequence: hierarchy among souls becomes possible, which underwrites gradation in liberation and the severe classification of bound souls.

3 jīva–jaḍa-bheda — Soul differs from matter. Consequence: consciousness is never reducible to the material order, and bondage is a real relation between distinct realities.

4 īśvara–jaḍa-bheda — God differs from matter. Consequence: God governs matter as its efficient cause without becoming its material cause — the point that separates Madhva from the other two schools.

5 jaḍa–jaḍa-bheda — Matter differs from matter. Consequence: the plural world is ontologically robust and cannot be reduced to one substance.

WHAT INSEPARABLE DEPENDENCE BUYS
- non-duality: only ONE ultimate substantive whole
- real difference: modes are genuine, not illusory
- devotion: the God-soul relation stays meaningful
- it answers Advaita's monism and Dvaita's pluralism at one stroke

MADHVA'S REPLY AND THE COST OF DIFFERENCE
- a body is an INSTRUMENT; a real self cannot be another's instrument
- so Madhva keeps dependence and drops the body-relation
- criticism: eternal difference risks ultimate pluralism and hierarchy
- reply: plurality is created reality, not defect; residue: graded destinies

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Advaita: identity without real plurality. Visistadvaita: inseparable plurality within unity. Dvaita: eternal plurality with dependence. Supremacy is defined by INDEPENDENCE, not absorption.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Ramanuja denies that the many must either dissolve into the one or stand outside it; Madhva denies that difference needs any unity beyond dependence to be intelligible.

TRAP — Aprthaksiddhi is not identity, and fivefold difference is FIVE — 'difference between God and world' is compatible with qualified non-dualism and proves nothing.

15 STAGE 15 WIDER VEDĀNTA, CONSEQUENCES OF ABSOLUTISM, AND THE GRADED VERDICT

- ● DVAITĀDVAITA · ŚUDDHĀDVAITA · ACINTYABHEDĀBHEDA
- ● PRĀKṚTA · APRĀKṚTA · KĀLA
- ● AVIKṚTA-PARIṆĀMA
- ● PUṢṬI-MĀRGA
- ● PRADHĀNA-MALLA
- ● PRACCHANNA-BAUDDHA

SCHOOL — 2018 Q7(a)	METAPHYSICAL RELATION	DIRECT PATH	LIBERATED CONDITION
Viśiṣṭādvaita	real inseparable mode and body of the absolute	devotion or surrender with grace	unobstructed knowledge, bliss, communion and service without identity
Dvaita	distinct dependent reality	right knowledge, devotion, grace	eternal service with graded bliss and permanent difference
Śuddhādvaita (Vallabha)	real UNCHANGED manifestations of Kṛṣṇa	grace-nourished loving devotion	participation in divine bliss and loving service; the world is not sublated
Acintyabhedābheda	simultaneously dependent non-difference and real difference	loving devotion culminating in divine love	eternal loving relation; individuality remains

NIMBĀRKA ON MATTER — 2020 Q5(e)
- ordinary primordial matter (prākṛta): material nature and its products
- non-prakritic divine substance (aprākṛta)
- time (kāla); placement of time varies — state the classification adopted
- matter is real, transformable and dependent: neither illusion nor a second absolute

ŚAṂKARA AGAINST SĀṂKHYA
- the cause must be CONSCIOUS: scripture describes it as knowing and purposive
- teleology requires intelligence; guṇa-disturbance does not explain ordered creation
- the witness-matter proximity relation is unintelligible
- the Upaniṣadic cause is ONE, not dual
- reply available to Sāṃkhya: constitutional orientation; internal scriptural appeal

1 FIVE CONSEQUENCES — 2019 Q8(a) — World reduced to appearance · individuality and agency provisional · ethics and karma empirical · devotion preparatory · instruments empirically valid only.

2 THE SELF-REFERENTIAL TENSION — Advaita uses reason and scripture to establish a truth that finally relativises reason and scripture. Ladder-model reply: self-cancellation is orderly because it coincides with the removal of the ignorance that made the instrument necessary.

3 THE CRYPTO-BUDDHIST CHARGE — It FAILS as identification: the absolute is a positive self-luminous reality, scripture is accepted, and consciousness-only doctrine is refuted. It SUCCEEDS as pressure: the shared denial of ultimate world-reality remains a polemical point. Advaita is NOT subjective idealism.

ADVAITA — GRADED VERDICT
- STRONG: non-duality, self-luminosity, sublation, liberation as recognition
- WEAK: world, individuality, ethics and devotion become lower-order
- CONTESTED: the locus and the proof of ignorance

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA — GRADED VERDICT
- STRONG: divine personality, real world, real selves, scriptural theism
- WEAK: real modes press on divine simplicity and changelessness
- CONTESTED: whether qualification enriches or limits absoluteness

DVAITA — GRADED VERDICT
- STRONG: realist basis for devotion, responsibility, permanent relation
- WEAK: eternal difference risks ultimate pluralism
- CONTESTED: hierarchy among souls and the unique differentiator

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Closing lines by marks — 10: Advaita sublates plurality, Visistadvaita qualifies unity, Dvaita absolutises difference. 15: judge them by their different criteria of reality. 20: a three-way contest between sublation, inseparability and real difference.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Vedanta debate is finally about what counts as preserving the absolute: Sankara by refusing it relation, Ramanuja by making relation internal, Madhva by making relation external and permanent.

TRAP — Never let a Western parallel exceed one or two lines, never end with 'both views have merit', and never claim the 2018 Samkhya question as Vedanta-owned.

E STAGE E OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

- ● USE AT MOST ONE MOVE PER ANSWER
- ● AFTER THE CORE SPINE IS SECURE
- ● EVALUATIVE PARAGRAPH ONLY

LOCUS OF IGNORANCE AS AN EXPLANATORY PROBLEM
- Bhāmatī emphasis on the individual; Vivaraṇa on the absolute as support
- later Advaitins treat it as a post-experiential explanatory problem
- one line only, in the evaluation of illusion, error or the seven objections

BEYOND ONE MODEL OF INDIVIDUALITY
- reflection, limitation and semblance answer different pressures
- objection: plurality of models signals instability
- reply: pedagogic metaphors, never fully unified by the tradition

MADHVA'S HIERARCHY AND DIFFERENTIATED LIBERATION
- gradation plus the classification of bound souls
- objection: graded souls compromise moral universality
- use only where hierarchy or grace is directly relevant

This stage is deliberately subordinate. Nothing above it is required to answer any of the twenty owned previous-year questions; the Basic spine in stages 00–15 is independently answer-complete.